LA CUCINA ITALIANA - SEMPLICE ITALIAN KITCHEN | BUDGET-FRIENDLY ITALIAN

What Is Cucina Povera? Traditional Italian Cooking on a Budget (+ Master Peasant Stew Recipe)

Discover What Is Cucina Povera-the art of traditional Italian cooking on a budget-plus a master 30-minute peasant legume & pasta recipe with free PDF.

Prep: 10 mins | Cook: 20 mins | Total: 30 mins | Yield: 4 servings ($1.65/serving) | Calories: 430 kcal

INGREDIENTS CHECKLIST

[ ] 250g (9 oz) Ditalini or Broken Spaghetti Pasta (pantry staple short pasta)
[ ] 2 cans (400g each) Canned Chickpeas & Cannellini Beans (undrained with starchy liquid)
[ ] 3 tbsp Extra Virgin Olive Oil (plus extra for finishing drizzle)
[ ] 3 cloves garlic, 2 sprigs rosemary Fresh Garlic Cloves & Rosemary Sprig
[ ] 2 tbsp Tomato Paste or Crushed Tomatoes
[ ] 4 slices Day-Old Crusty Italian Bread (toasted for serving)

STEP-BY-STEP CULINARY INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Infuse the Rosemary & Garlic Oil [2 mins]
Warm 3 tablespoons of olive oil in a heavy pot over medium-low heat. Add crushed garlic cloves and fresh rosemary sprigs, letting them sizzle gently for 2 minutes until fragrant.

Step 2: Caramelize Tomato Paste & Add Legumes [8 mins]
Stir in the tomato paste for 1 minute to deepen its sweetness. Pour in the chickpeas and beans along with their flavorful canning liquid plus 2 cups of water.

Step 3: The Cucina Povera Creaminess Trick [2 mins]
Use an immersion blender (or potato masher) to pulse 1/4 of the beans directly in the pot. This creates a thick, velvety broth without a drop of dairy cream.

Step 4: Simmer Pasta Directly in the Broth [10 mins]
Add the dry pasta straight into the simmering bean broth and cook for 9 to 10 minutes, stirring frequently so the pasta starch thickens the stew. Serve over toasted day-old bread with a swirl of raw olive oil.

CHEF'S PRO TIPS & STORAGE

* The Core Rule of Cucina Povera: Never throw away pasta cooking water, bean liquid (aquafaba), or stale bread-they are the natural thickeners of traditional Italian cooking.
* Save Parmigiano-Reggiano rinds in your freezer and drop one into any bean or vegetable soup while it simmers for deep umami flavor.